

they're notoriously susceptible to subtle bugs (as discussed at <https://softwareengineering.stackexchange.com/q/59880>).

But it's perfectly legal to have the following Python code:

---

```
>>> spam = --spam
>>> spam
42
```

---

The first detail you should notice is that the ++ and -- “operators” in Python don't actually increment or decrement the value in *spam*. Rather, the leading - is Python's unary negation operator. It allows you to write code like this:

---

```
>>> spam = 42
>>> -spam
-42
```

---

It's legal to have multiple unary negative operators in front of a value. Using two of them gives you the negative of the negative of the value, which for integer values just evaluates to the original value:

---

```
>>> spam = 42
>>> -(-spam)
42
```

---

This is a very silly operation to perform, and you likely won't ever see a unary negation operator used twice in real-world code. (But if you did, it's probably because the programmer learned to program in another language and has just written buggy Python code!)

There is also a + unary operator. It evaluates an integer value to the same sign as the original value, which is to say, it does absolutely nothing:

---

```
>>> spam = 42
>>> +spam
42
>>> spam = -42
>>> +spam
-42
```

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